Happenings in Handmade

A CCI initiative

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GOLDEN GRASS

Weaving worlds together

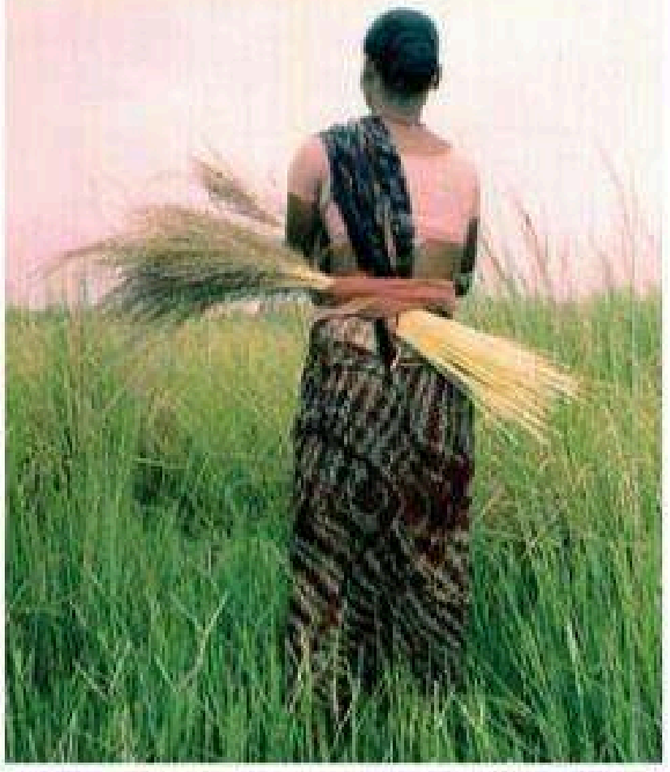


From the sun-kissed savannahs of Brazil to the coastal plains of Orissa, different kinds of **golden grass** weave a common thread of tradition, sustainability and beauty into exquisite pieces of art.











Orissa's golden grass, (*Kaincha* or *Kans*), is a **wild grass** that springs up after the first monsoon in the marshy areas of Jagatsinghpur and Kendrapara districts. It grows to a height of about 5-6 feet and the inflorescent stick is used for weaving. The women wade through water to collect the grass and split each stem into 2 equal strands with their teeth. As the grass is dried, it changes colour, taking on a tinge of golden yellow.



The grass is woven into beautiful mats, baskets, wall hangings, often featuring tribal motifs and geometric patterns, using techniques passed down over the centuries, from mother to daughter, who brought with her a ‘dala’ or large golden grass tray, bearing sarees and sweets for her in-laws during the wedding. This ecofriendly craft is helping to change lives, providing people with a steady source of income through self-help groups.





The Brazilian golden grass (*Capim Duorado*) is not a grass but **the stem** of a delicate flowering plant called *sempre viva* that grows up to 2 feet and dries to a high shine in the sun. It is harvested in September. The intrinsic metallic hue that comes from different flavonoid compounds makes it resemble a golden wire.





The *Capim Duorado* is native to Jalapão, in the vast ecoregion of tropical grassland where the local population weaves the unique fibre into utilitarian objects and decorations: fruit bowls, hats, baskets, and jewelry. It is currently one of the most important sources of income for women artisans in this predominantly rural area. During the Golden Grass Festival, people gather for food, music and demonstrations, where artisans display their skill.





Two worlds apart, the golden grasses of Brazil and Orissa come alive in the skilled hands of artisans, bridging cultures and continents.







Sources

The Golden Grass Company
Atlas Obscura
D'Source
Unnayan
Weve Story